Notably, a subset of Hindus is not cremated here: sadhus, lepers, small children, pregnant women and snake-bite victims. They're consigned directly to the sacred river. Their corpses, it is said, do not need further purification by fire, so they're taken in a boat to the middle of the Ganga, tied to a stone and sunk to the bottom, becoming food for fish and river turtles. Some of these corpses, or parts thereof, later float up to the surface, spooking unsuspecting tourists. The liturgy of death in Varanasi is not for the squeamish.[47]



Figure 9. Funeral pyres on Manikarnika Ghat

The funeral pyres of course cause a great deal of air pollution. It's harder on the Doms who spend hours enveloped in wood smoke. Their eyes water, one Dom says. They cough and feel short of breath. Most quit this work in middle age owing to *kamjori* (physical weakness). In 1984, to provide a faster, cheaper and less smoky alternative, the government installed an